

RAISING THE BAR

BAR ■ CHINA HOUSE, MUMBAI

The silken rope is the real celebrity at China House. Ever since the bar opened at the Grand Hyatt six months back, hordes have queued up patiently to be allowed past the barrier. Flanked by private dining areas and booths that are booked for anything upwards of Rs 50,000 and Rs 25,000, respectively, the bar occupies a prime location in the middle of the lounge. Seven bartenders shake the martinis, pour the single malts and flame the shots by the second, especially on weekends when the consumption of vodka alone goes up to 25 bottles. The collection of 20 single malts and 320 labels of wine aside, there's another reason why China House is on

everyone's map—star gazing. While most A-listers reserve a table or booth, those who don't are quietly ushered to the I Deck, a mezzanine area originally created for private parties that now serves as a celebrity den. Kareena Kapoor made one of her first public appearances with Saif Ali Khan here and liked the sour apple martini so much that she downed seven in a matter of hours. And fighting for star status with the silken ropes are the closing hours. Unlike every other bar in Mumbai that shuts at 1.30 a.m., China House remains open till 3 a.m.—every night of the week. And the best part: there's no entry charge.

by Jhilmil Motihar

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MANDAR DEODHAR